

For most of my adult life, this was not a problem for me – I very much leaned towards the overspending end of the spectrum, even when money was very tight. I gained some insight, though, after I finished paying off my debt and was starting to build some savings. I was even earning more than I had done previously, and had a lot more income at my disposal, but I would freeze before buying things, even when they were things that I or my family needed. Shortly after *Real Life Money* was published, the years-old, barely functioning laptop that I wrote it on started to overheat after about thirty minutes of use. I had promised myself that, when it stopped working, I'd buy myself something decent – a MacBook, which I've always preferred, despite the cries of 'It's a waste unless you use all the design features' – and now was the moment. I had the cash, it was deductible as a business expense, and I was able to get a discount. But I couldn't do it. I dithered and dithered, only going through with the purchase when I grew so frustrated by my computer that I almost threw it out of the window. I found it very difficult, emotionally, to part with that cash, and the MacBook, when it arrived, felt *illicit*. I didn't feel deserving of it, and I dwelled on what else that cash could have paid for more than was healthy.

Otegha Uwagba describes this anxiety in far more detail and with far deeper context in her memoir, *We Need to Talk About Money*.² Her painful awareness of the fact that her family did not have enough money while she was a child led her to cling to money as an adult, and she describes how her relationship